



*"A day, an hour of virtuous liberty,
Is worth a whole Eternity to bondage."*

—ADDISON.

SYDNEY, JULY 1, 1895.

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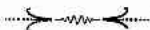
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THE SIR JOHN ROBERTSON MEMORIAL FUND.



THE late Sir John Robertson was the father of the system, for settling farmers on the land, known as "Free Selection" or "Free Selection before Survey," which, with all its faults, was, perhaps, the best and fairest thing that could be done for the settler at that time; and so, on this account alone, and apart from his many sterling qualities, every free selector's son should take an interest in, and assist to the best of his ability, the movement to have a monument erected to the memory of the veteran statesman. And every schoolmaster might find time—a few minutes—to tell the children something about Sir John Robertson and his work in connection with education, and placing of the people on the land in New South Wales.

Old Sir John hated humberg and told what he considered to be the truth—in strong language sometimes, and sometimes when it wasn't wanted, but yet he told it—he did what he thought best for the settlers and their children. He stands forward as the first prominent figure in Australian legis-

lation, and surely he deserves a statue as well as many in whose memory monuments have been erected in Australia, in whose lives we had no interest; whose names we had no cause to remember—and have indeed forgotten—and whose influence, whether for good or evil—Australians never felt.

The agitation to have a national monument placed over Sir John Robertson's grave was started a few weeks ago in Sydney, and influential meetings have been held in the city and elsewhere. The proposal has met with the heartiest approval of the press, members of parliament and business men. Subscriptions in aid of the fund may be limited to one shilling. A considerable sum has already been collected.

As the Editress of this paper has been requested to join the committee, opportunities are offered our subscribers to assist in this important movement. All shilling contributions will be gladly received at this office and acknowledged in our columns.

Any responsible person willing to collect for the fund can have a subscription list forwarded to him or her on application.

→✱ A FEMALE ROBINSON CRUSOE. ✱←



SAN NICOLAS ISLAND is one of a cluster in the Bay of Santa Barbara, California. Here for eighteen years lived the "Lost Woman of San Nicolas." The story of her life is a strange one. In 1835 the Alaska Indians were removed from the islands by the Government. One "white Indian woman" went ashore for her child, and was left behind. No attempt was made to rescue her, but sixteen years later a casual visitor to the island discovered footprints of a woman and evidences of her life. She could not, however, be discovered then or in the following year. The Catholic Fathers of the 'Old Mission,' the foremost in every good word and work, offered a reward to any one who would find the lost woman, and a third effort was made in 1853.

discover the prodigal about whom there was such a mystery, and in whom the world of this coast was beginning to take an interest. Fresh tracks of the woman were found. They belonged to very small feet, and were like those that were seen in the first attempt to find the woman. Huts made of whale ribs and covered with brush were discovered. At length an object was seen in the distance that appeared to be moving. Going toward it, they saw the woman that for eighteen years had reigned Queen of San Nicolas, her subjects being the wild animals, her robe a dress of bird-skins, and her throne the hut she had built. She was seated in an enclosure, so that only her head and shoulders could be seen. Two or three dogs were about her, that disappeared at the command of their sovereign. She was seated on some grass that covered the ground and served her as a bed. Her dress was neatly made of bird-skins, extending to her ankles, the feathers of which pointed downward. Her head was covered with a thick mat of yellowish-brown hair, and her shoulders were bare. She

was occupied in stripping blubber from a piece of sealskin which she had across her knee, and using for that purpose a knife made of an iron hoop. In her hut was a fire, beside which she sat talking to herself, and, occasionally shading her eyes with her hand, looked at the men that were in search of her. She received them with much courtesy, bowing and smiling, and showing that this lost child of Nature had much of the politeness of a true woman. She took some roots from the bag, roasted them in the fire, and gave them to the men to eat. She gathered up all her food, which was her chief concern, owing to the famine she had experienced, washed herself at the spring, and followed the men cheerfully to the boat. On being taken to Santa Barbara, she manifested great delight on seeing the sights of civilization. She became a universal favorite, and was presented with many gifts. Passengers on the Panama steamer that landed there all wanted to see the lost woman of San Nicolas. She related by signs her experience on the island, as she spoke a language that none of the Spanish fathers, versed in Indian dialects, could understand. Civilization, which prolongs the life of some, shortened that of the woman of San Nicolas. An excessive love of fruit led to her death in San Barbara at the age of fifty. She was buried with the Catholic Church by the Franciscan Fathers, and her dress and trinkets were sent to Rome and placed in that receptacle of the world's curiosities.

The story of the lost woman of San Nicolas will always remain a wonderment. Her ingenuity is seen in the pails she made of grass, made to hold water by smearing them with melted asphaltum, and in her bird-skin dresses, her bone needles, her knife of iron hoop, and the language she invented and spoke. It is inexplicable to all who have learned her story, how a woman could live eighteen years on an

island, around which the waves were beating a requiem to hope, getting her food and cooking it without even those facilities which are common to the savage, and making her dresses neatly without the aid of needles except what she carved out of bone. She laid aside one dress for eighteen years, to be worn when the white men should come, of which she had a presentiment. She built her own house,

protected herself from the cold, gained supreme control over the wild beasts about her, and preserved her love for men and women for well-nigh two decades of human life alone in the wild. With no previous knowledge of civilization, solitude appeared to have educated her for it. An ordinary woman would have perished with despondency in such a desolate hungry, naked, hopeless outlook.

Would We Forget?

HOME, sweet home of childhood! Outworn phrase never will it be. What olden memories, clear and distinct, come to us as we leave for a few moments our monotonous round of work and lay bare the graves of Memory. We look down the decades of years to our childhood's home and what does Memory bring to us from out the past? Plans formed for the future before our lives were narrowed down through contact with the great false world, dreams and aspirations that had so little of self and so much of that wider and wiser humanity,—alas, practised so little by us now—unsullied days of longings for a larger and better life. What an exquisite sense of calm and comfort is ours as we live again in the past. Deep and earnest thoughts which may never find speech come to us, urging us, to fulfil in the future lying before us what we hoped for in that far-away time from these plans and dreams of a pure and stainless youth. Would we forget these?

And now, these mellow days past, Memory brings us again to riper years when pain and loss were hard to hear, when burdens were laid upon us, when burdens were lifted, days of bitter grief and weariness, days of joy and

contentment, "no rose plucked without, a thorn." The memory of these chequered days of light, and darkness flashes on us across the years of life and we linger awhile, with rapturous joy akin to pain, to think of the kindly human sympathy and affection which strengthened us, cheered us, and wearied not. These things we would never forget.

Sometimes,

"When the sun is low

And thronging fancies come and go"

our hearts ache with an intense pity as we see the loved boy who has almost wrecked his life, going home to die, weeping tears of pity and contrition away down in the valley of humiliation for wrong doing. Who would forget the loved form lying with closed eyes which will never again be opened in this world, who died with mother's hand tightly clasped in his, his last words breathing "Peace, lovely peace" at last for the sin-stained but forgiven wanderer.

O, Light of Memory! thou holdest the very secrets of our lives, thou knowest our hopes and joys, our sadness and regret. We droop beneath the anguish of thy unveiling power when our souls are laid bare by thee, and yet thou art mysteriously fascinating. We would not forget if we could.

L.C.S.